The National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA) will present the world premiere of *The Absence of PRESENCE*, a new interdisciplinary work by dancer and choreographer Aditi Mangaldas, the Symphony Orchestra of India (SOI) and composer Rushil Ranjan. Commissioned by the NCPA, the production brings together Kathak, contemporary movement, symphonic music, poetry and visual art to reflect on children caught in conflict, the human tendency to look away and the possibility of resilience and hope.

For Mangaldas, the work emerged from witnessing images of the conflict in Gaza being streamed in real time. The suffering of children, she says, was difficult to comprehend and translate into movement. "Art has the possibility of resonating across borders, space and time," she says. "Sustained resonance does not allow the mind to ignore, be indifferent and silent towards the tragedy unfolding around us."

The production brings Mangaldas's movement vocabulary into dialogue with a symphonic score by Ranjan, whose music draws on Hindustani classical and the rhythmic language of Kathak within a western orchestral framework.

"For me, that meeting has to happen in the actual writing: how a phrase develops, how rhythm creates tension, how the harmony changes what you feel underneath a melody," says Ranjan. The orchestra allows Ranjan to move between intimate human experience and the overwhelming scale of conflict. "The orchestra can express something deeply private, but it can also become the machinery, violence and scale of the world surrounding the individual," he says.

For Mangaldas, the music helped express aspects of grief that movement alone could not. The work, however, does not



ADARSH PRATHAP

THEATRE ▼

Celebrating Bonds

With double the premiering productions and decades-old partnerships at its heart, PRITHVI FESTIVAL 2026 returns to Mumbai

One of Mumbai's most iconic cultural gatherings, the Prithvi Festival is returning to Juhu in Prithvi Theatre's 48th year. Bringing together English, Hindi, Marathi, Tibetan and Urdu voices, the 16-day extravaganza features premiere productions, live acoustic music, fringe showcases and masterclass workshops.

This year's edition is defined by an exciting expansion, boasting almost double the number of premiering productions. Calling it a "problem of plenty," Zahan Kapoor, trustee, Prithvi Theatre, hopes to "facilitate a sense of joy and togetherness across the artists and the audiences".

Central to the festival's identity is its deep-rooted network of creative relationships with returning playwrights, directors, actors and music collaborators. Highlighting this ethos, trustee Kunal Kapoor shares, "It takes mutual respect and mutual appreciation to make the partnerships work. It is very important to us as part of our DNA."

During the 16 days,

CENTRAL TO THE FESTIVAL'S IDENTITY IS ITS DEEP-ROOTED TIES WITH RETURNING PLAYWRIGHTS, DIRECTORS, ACTORS AND MUSIC COLLABORATORS